And what was that?

‘On the afternoon of 21 May, my wife saw our neighbour, Nalini, with the girl in green-and-orange salwar kameez carrying the garland, and the short man wearing the white kurta pyjama, just like in the photograph from the papers. There was another woman with them. All of them went out together in the afternoon that day when Rajiv Gandhi was killed.’ He paused and looked at everyone around one by one, as if trying to see if they believed his words.

It only took a second for Verma and Ragothaman to realize that the man had come with a very important piece of information. The name of Nalini had appeared in the notebook seized from the LTTE operative Koneswaran after his arrest from Vedaranyam, following which the ‘Q Branch’ had looked into her antecedents. Verma encouraged him to carry on.

‘Who is Nalini?’

‘My neighbour, sir. She is reserved by nature; she seldom speaks with the neighbours. I hear she was the private secretary of the managing director of a company in Adyar.’

He paused and looked around. He was shown the photographs taken by Haribabu. The man immediately identified Nalini sitting with another woman in the women’s enclosure.

‘Please carry on,’ said Ragothaman.

‘Another boy called “Das” would often visit Nalini.’

‘Where is your house?’ Verma asked.

‘In Villivakkam, in High Court Colony, sir.’

‘Any idea if Nalini was there when you left home to come here today?’

‘No, sir, she left home on 26 May and has not returned since. Her office is in Adyar, sir.’

‘Thank you so much. Please call us if you see something or someone suspicious.’

Ragothaman saw him off at the reception and returned to Verma.

‘Bad luck, sir! Wish he had suspected Nalini before seeing our appeal in the newspapers.’

‘We have a tail on the photographer Ravi Shankar, right?’